CERNO GLOBUS

FIELD INTELLIGENCE

Issue 005 Tuesday, October 13, 2026 · Biweekly, 4 pages

Practices

Dental · Veterinary · Aesthetics · Chiropractic & Physical Therapy · Optometry & Vision · Behavioral & Mental Health

Six trades, one publication. Every item is something that moves a number on your P&L, changes what you must do by law, or changes what parts and labor cost you.

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BACKGROUND SIGNAL
The fraud that reads your invoices before it sends one

Read it online
This issue, and every one before it

MONEY

Nearly two in five dentists say they are not busy enough in the third quarter, up from about one in four in Q2, while reimbursement gains trail inflation.

The ADA Health Policy Institute's Q3 2026 update, built on a September 14 dentist survey and federal data through early October, finds nearly two in five dentists not busy enough, up from about one-quarter in Q2. The wait for a new-patient appointment fell to a series low of 12.0 business days from 13.9 in Q2. The share calling themselves too busy and overworked is the lowest in years.

Money is not keeping pace. From January through August, the all-payer dental reimbursement index rose 1.5% against 2.3% for consumer prices. Dental office hourly earnings rose less than 0.1% and equipment and supply prices 0.2%. Inflation-adjusted consumer dental spending is down 2.4% year to date and 0.9% from a year earlier, at $209 billion annualized in August.

Confidence is split. Of dentists surveyed, 40.9% are confident about the dental sector and 36.9% skeptical, and their confidence in the U.S. economy is at its lowest in several years. University of Michigan consumer sentiment, at 51.7, is near its lowest since 2021. Dental office jobs rose 0.4% in September and 0.8% over twelve months, after peaking in May.

Hiring stays hard even with softer demand: among dentists who were recruiting, 88.3% call hygienist recruiting very or extremely challenging, and 76.8% say the same of assistants, up from 68.2% in Q2. Only 9.6% of hygienist openings filled within two weeks, against 12.1% a year earlier, and 21.2% took more than six months.

What to do about it: Count open chair hours per provider for the last 90 days. If you sit in the not-busy two in five, fix recall and unscheduled-treatment follow-up before you cut anyone. Re-run each plan's allowable against your overhead per chair hour and list the plans paying below it before you decide to leave any network, because leaving without a plan to fill the chairs costs more than a low fee. Ask your top three payers in writing for their 2027 fee schedules. Write down what a vacant hygiene or assistant seat costs you per week, since 88.3% of dentists recruiting hygienists and 76.8% of those recruiting assistants call those hires hard. Hold non-urgent equipment purchases until fourth-quarter collections are in.

ADA HPI: State of the U.S. Dental Economy, Q3 2026

DENTAL

TWO ITEMS

SUPPLY

Flumazenil injection is on back order at Baxter, Fresenius Kabi and Hikma, with restock estimates from early to late October; some state laws may require sedating dentists to stock it.

Why it matters: Flumazenil reverses benzodiazepine overdose in oral sedation. A September 21 shortage bulletin lists Baxter's 5 mL and 10 mL vials on back order with no estimate, Fresenius Kabi's 10 mL vials due early October and 5 mL mid-October, and Hikma's 10 mL vials mid- to late October, with its 5 mL still available. Those dates may have moved. If you sedate, count unexpired vials today, check your state board's reversal-agent rule, and ask your distributor for an allocation in writing before a gap opens.

ADA News: Manufacturers report flumazenil shortage

REGULATION

The ADA asked Senate Finance on September 29 to extend insurance reform to stand-alone and self-funded dental plans and to the administrators that process their claims.

Why it matters: The letter answers Sen. Wyden's "Health Coverage That Works for Everyone" request for information. It seeks state waivers to apply prompt-payment, prior-authorization, retroactive-denial and recoupment limits to self-funded plans, backs H.R. 7931, and asks for dental loss-ratio reporting, since stand-alone plans are generally exempt from the ACA's medical loss-ratio rule. States have enacted 400 dental insurance reforms. Nothing changes your contracts yet. Log retroactive denials and recoupments by plan with dates and dollars; your state dental society can use that record.

ADA News: ADA urges Senate Finance on dental in reform

VETERINARY

TWO ITEMS

MONEY

The AVMA's 2026 Practice Owners Survey puts average 2025 gross revenue at $1,572,379, the first rise since 2022, but revenue per square foot fell to $513 from $528.

Why it matters: The gain is about 0.3% after inflation. Revenue per veterinarian is about $671,830 and per exam room $503,988. Patients per FTE veterinarian per day held near 15 in companion-animal-exclusive practices and fell from 18 to 16 in companion-animal-predominant ones. Active clients per veterinarian dropped to 1,749 from 1,987. Owners reporting AI use rose from 18% to 35%. This week, compute your own revenue per square foot and per exam room and compare.

AVMA News: Veterinary practice health, mixed report card

LABOR

AVMA's 2026 senior survey puts new-graduate pay at $131,784 and debt among borrowers at $227,588, and says their pay gap to all veterinarians widened from 19% to 28%.

Why it matters: Private-practice starts average $133,056, public practice $101,234, internships $59,436. Real income fell for new graduates while it rose for all veterinarians, whose 2025 average was $163,014. Among full-time hires, 58.7% got signing bonuses, 34.6% moving allowances and 19.9% loan repayment. Full-time employment is 58.0% and 7.4% had no offer, up from 2.1% in 2022. Before posting an associate role, price a signing bonus and loan-repayment package.

AVMA News: New graduates face rising debt, lower income

AESTHETICS

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

CDC reported October 8 that three patients of a Colorado medical spa had botulism-type symptoms after injections from one FDA-unapproved lot of botulinum toxin bought online.

Why it matters: All three recovered and none was hospitalized, but none knew the product was unapproved. Inspectors also found single-dose vials used on multiple patients, a preservative-containing diluent used improperly, poor temperature monitoring, and reconstituted product used past its beyond-use date. The provider got a public health order and a complaint to the state regulator. FDA sent a Texas med spa a warning letter in April for buying toxin in violation of the Drug Supply Chain Security Act. This week, match every toxin vial on your shelf to a distributor invoice and pull anything you cannot trace.

CDC MMWR: Unapproved botulinum toxin at a medical spa

REGULATION

Maine's joint medical, osteopathic and nursing board rule for medical spas and IV therapy, effective July 2026, bars standing orders and menu-based IV orders and requires a prescriber exam before any infusion.

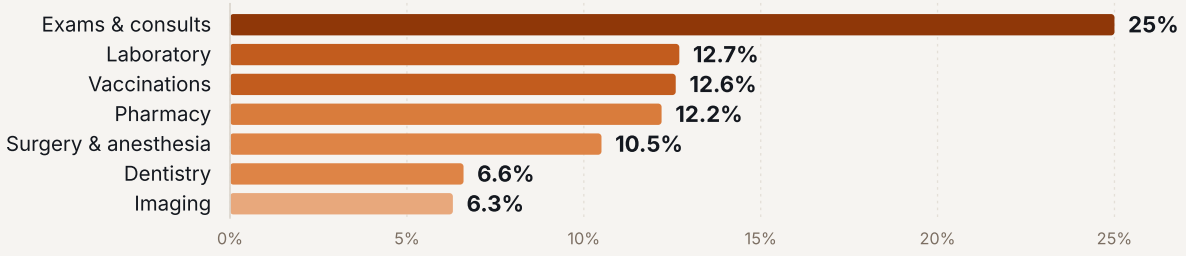
Why it matters: AmSpa reported it July 23, 2026, and the rule took effect in July 2026. Only an individual order from a licensed prescriber counts, a static online questionnaire is not an exam, and medical assistants may not give IV therapy. Licensed physicians must mix IV bags in the office, USP <797> applies, and walk-in, mobile and concierge IV services do not get the immediate-use exception. Prescribers using drugs on FDA's shortage list for elective use must chart the basis. If you run printed IV menus anywhere, replace them with patient-specific orders.

AmSpa: New IV Rules in Maine

INFOGRAPHIC 1 / VET REVENUE MIX

Examinations bring in about a quarter of every veterinary revenue dollar, roughly double the next-largest profit center, laboratory work at 12.7 cents.

Share of 2025 practice gross revenue by profit center, percent; AVMA 2026 Practice Owners Survey, 775 practices, published October 8, 2026



Seven centers make up 85.1% of revenue. Exams are plotted at the AVMA's published 'about 25 cents.' Lab, vaccines and pharmacy each bring in about 12 cents. Pull your own mix by service code and compare line by line. AVMA News: Veterinary practice health, mixed report card

CHIROPRACTIC & PHYSICAL THERAPY

TWO ITEMS

MONEY

APTA's GOALS pilot with Hartford HealthCare Rehabilitation Network tracks function, falls, hospitalizations and emergency visits in older adults with frailty, to build evidence for value-based physical therapy payment.

Why it matters: The pilot runs a year and began in July; APTA's podcast page is dated September 22. APTA's pages publish no payment arrangement, start date or eligibility. APTA's October 1 magazine feature says value-based care has an uncomfortable place in physical therapy and that the distance is shrinking. Nothing pays you differently today. The action is data: record a validated function score at intake and discharge for every older patient, plus falls in the prior 12 months, in a form you can export. If a payer or ACO offers a value-based contract, those records are your leverage.

APTA Podcast: The APTA GOALS Model · APTA Magazine: From Visits to Value

DEMAND

October is National Chiropractic Health Month under the theme "Joint Efforts," and the ACA on October 6 asked members and patients to make candidates aware of chiropractic issues, including Medicare coverage, before the November 3 election.

Why it matters: No dollar figures accompany the campaign. The ACA's September 15 release offers a public site, handsdownbetter.org, and the hashtag #JointEfforts, with no practice offers or pricing. The October 6 note names H.R. 539 and S. 106, the Chiropractic Medicare Coverage Modernization Act, and says Medicare changes are on the table without detail. Nothing changes what you bill. The cheap use: send a joint-health message to your patient list this month, recall inactive patients, and ask patients to write the local paper, one of the asks in the October 6 note.

ACA: Chiropractors to promote joint health in October · ACA: Make voices heard on the campaign trail

OPTOMETRY & VISION

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

California enacted the Strengthening Medi-Cal Vision Services Act requiring evidence-based eye-care utilization benchmarks, after a report found only 16% of school-age Medi-Cal children received any vision services in two years.

Why it matters: AOA reported it September 30. The California Optometric Association's report counted more than 4 million children without vision services. The visible AOA text gives no targets, effective date or rate change, and the full article is members-only, so nothing changes your fees yet. If you see Medi-Cal patients, ask your state association for the statute text and benchmark timeline. If you do not, a 16% use rate marks unmet demand for child exams in your market worth a recall or school-screening push.

AOA: New California law sets Medicaid vision benchmarks

INSURANCE

Illinois S.B. 3707 bars vision plans from requiring virtual credit cards with transaction fees, forcing discount-plan participation or demanding a security interest in practice assets.

Why it matters: AOA reported it August 25, 2026, and gives no effective date. It also requires notice of contract changes, access to fee schedules, contract terms of two years unless both sides agree otherwise, and protects providers who report violations. Providers may offer a lower cash-pay price when it beats the vision benefit. It is the second state vision-benefit law of 2026 after Louisiana. If you contract with a vision plan in Illinois, pull each agreement and flag any card-fee, discount-plan or collateral clause; elsewhere, use these terms as your asks at renewal.

AOA: Illinois enacts vision benefit protections

BEHAVIORAL & MENTAL HEALTH

TWO ITEMS

LABOR

Wellbeing First says 82 state licensing boards, 1,087 hospitals and 3,306 other facilities now verify their applications omit intrusive mental health questions, a 437% rise in protected workers since 2023.

Why it matters: ADA News reported it October 9. About 3.6 million licensed workers are covered by board changes and 558,000 credentialed workers by facility changes, of roughly 22 million U.S. health workers. Dental boards verified rose to ten from five. The count includes 46 medical, 13 pharmacy and 11 nursing boards. Minnesota and Virginia have reformed their questions but are not yet verified. For practices treating clinicians, fewer application barriers may widen your referral pool. If you employ licensed staff, audit your own credentialing forms with the coalition's resources.

ADA News: 4.1 million health workers, safer care path

MONEY

CMS rural health awards include $169.6 million for Colorado across 91 grantees (September 28 release) and $13 million for South Dakota with 12 grants to providers in its CCBHC initiative (September 24 release).

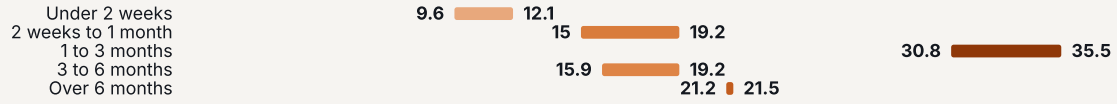
Why it matters: South Dakota's release, dated September 24, funds a same-day 24/7 mobile crisis response and 12 modernization and infrastructure grants; per-grant amounts and application steps are not published. Colorado's September 28 release covers about 250 projects, with behavioral health and substance use care among them. Neither release gives deadlines; South Dakota's grants go to providers participating in its CCBHC initiative. If you are a CCBHC or rural behavioral provider, ask your state health agency this week who administers the subawards and when they open, and have your IT and workforce needs priced.

CMS: $13 million for South Dakota behavioral care · CMS: $169.6 million for Colorado rural health

INFOGRAPHIC 2 / HYGIENIST HIRING SPEED

Hygienist openings fill more slowly at the fast end: 9.6% fill within two weeks against 12.1% a year ago, while a fifth still take over six months.

Share of dentists by time to fill a hygienist opening, percent; each bar spans the Q3 2025 and Q3 2026 readings; ADA Health Policy Institute Q3 2026 update

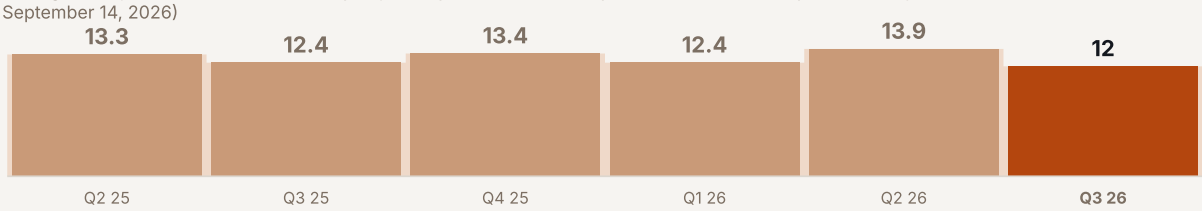


Each bar runs from the lower to the higher of the two readings. The share filling in one to three months fell to 30.8% from 35.5% while two weeks to one month rose to 19.2% from 15.0%. The long tail, over six months, barely moved at 21.2%. Plan on a three-month vacancy as normal and cover the chair with temps or cross-trained staff. ADA HPI: State of the U.S. Dental Economy, Q3 2026

INFOGRAPHIC 3 / NEW-PATIENT WAIT

New dental patients waited 12.0 business days for an appointment in Q3 2026, the shortest in the series, a sign of open schedule capacity.

Average new-patient wait in business days, quarterly; ADA Health Policy Institute dentist survey, Q3 2026 update (fielded September 14, 2026)



The wait jumped to 13.9 days in Q2 and fell to 12.0 in Q3, the lowest in a series that begins in Q1 2024 at 14.6. A shorter wait means open chairs, and nearly two in five dentists say they are not busy enough. Offer same-week new-patient slots and track fill rate by day. ADA HPI: State of the U.S. Dental Economy, Q3 2026

THE BACKGROUND SIGNAL

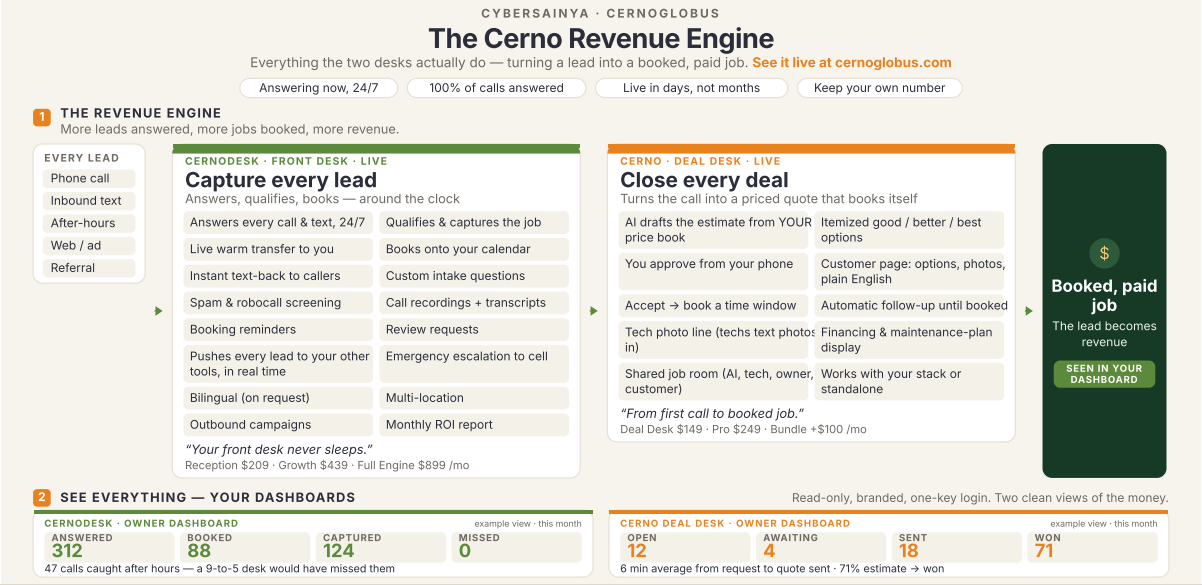
The fraud that reads your invoices before it sends one

The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center took 24,768 business email compromise reports in 2025, with losses of $3.05 billion — a record, after dipping to $2.77 billion in 2024 from $2.95 billion in 2023. Across all internet crime it logged 1,008,597 complaints and $20.88 billion in losses. Reported cases only, so read it as a floor.

Business email compromise, not ransomware, is the one that should concern an independent practice. Someone gets into a mailbox, reads until they understand how you invoice and who pays you, then sends a real-looking progress billing with different bank details. No malware, no warning — just a payment that never arrives and an argument about who eats it. A practice that emails claims, statements and supplier invoices all day is the shape this is built for. The quieter number is adoption: under 20% of firms with fewer than 20 staff use AI at all.

What to do about it: You don't need a security program. You need multi-factor authentication on email and your accounting login, and one rule everybody follows: nobody changes bank details on the strength of an email or a call — you ring the number you already had on file and confirm. That covers most of it, and costs nothing. The part it doesn't — how the systems are set up — is the day job of our parent company, CyberSainya.

FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center, 2025 Internet Crime Report — reported cases only, rounded from $2,946,830,270, $2,770,151,146 and $3,046,598,558. U.S. Census Bureau, Business Trends and Outlook Survey, May 3, 2026.



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